Parshas Acharei Mot-Kedoshim

Who Defines Value? Living as Kedoshim in the World

Acharei Mot · Kedoshim · Yom Kippur · Two Goats · Am Kadosh

I. After Death Comes Structure

We enter the double parsha of Acharei Mot-Kedoshim with a sobering reminder. וידבר ה׳ אל משה אחרי מות שני בני אהרן (Vayikra 16:1), Hashem spoke to Moshe after the death of Aharon's two sons. The parsha opens by recalling the tragic loss of Nadav and Avihu, who brought a ketores they weren't commanded to bring, at a time they weren't commanded to bring it, entering a place they weren't meant to enter. Some opinions among Chazal suggest they may have been intoxicated. But beyond the specific circumstances, the Torah is teaching us something fundamental about avodah and the framework within which it must operate.

As Rashi reminds us, "אין מוקדם ומאוחר בתורה", there is no absolute chronological order in the Torah. This event actually occurred several parshiyos earlier, but it's placed here deliberately. Because everything in Torah comes down to learning. "תורה היא הוראה", Torah is instruction, teaching us how to navigate our relationship with Hashem. The question the Torah is asking us: What happens when we serve Hashem based on what feels right to us, rather than what He has commanded?

II. Yom Kippur: The Corrective Framework

The Torah immediately responds to Nadav and Avihu's error by establishing the avodah of Yom Kippur. This becomes the corrective, the reset. Where Nadav and Avihu entered the Kodesh HaKodashim on their own initiative, the Torah now establishes that only one person may enter: the Kohen Gadol. Only at one specific time: Yom Kippur. Only in one specific way: following an elaborate, precisely defined protocol.

The avodah of Yom Kippur is extraordinarily structured. The Kohen Gadol immerses in the mikvah multiple times. He changes between different sets of garments repeatedly. Each step is measured, each action prescribed. Avodah after avodah after avodah, in exact sequence, with no room for personal innovation or inspiration-driven deviation. This is the lesson: Kedushah is not self-created. Kedushah is received. We don't define holiness through our feelings or our sense of what seems spiritually elevated. Hashem defines it, and we align ourselves with His definition.

III. Two Identical Goats: Who Decides What Is Best?

At the heart of the Yom Kippur service stands one of the most striking images in all of Torah: two goats, identical in appearance and value. A lottery is performed. "גורל אחד לה' וגורל אחד לעזאזל" (Vayikra 16:8), one lot for Hashem, one lot for Azazel. One goat is brought as a korban to Hashem. The other is sent to Azazel, pushed off a cliff in the wilderness. Both must be of the highest quality, completely identical.

This seems puzzling. Why must the goat sent to Azazel be just as valuable as the one offered to Hashem? And more fundamentally, who performs the lottery?

Rabbi Sholom Gordon, zichrono livracha, would address this question in his shiurim. People naturally ask: I understand why Hashem should receive the best, but why does Azazel also get the best? Why not send a lesser animal to Azazel and reserve the superior one for Hashem?

The answer, he explained, reveals something profound about human nature. If we were choosing, we would absolutely try to game the system. We'd pick the better one for Hashem and the lesser one for Azazel. We'd make the judgment ourselves about which is superior. But that's exactly the problem. Who am I to decide which is better? The Torah removes that decision entirely. The goats must be identical, and the goral, the lottery, decides their fate. Not my judgment. Not my assessment of value. Not my sense of what's appropriate. Because I do not define value. Hashem defines purpose.

IV. Where This Appears in Daily Life

This isn't just about goats and Yom Kippur. This is about how we live every day. Consider: A person might say, "I'll wear tefillin for 45 minutes during davening. That's sufficient." But when it comes to what car I drive, what people see on the outside, what projects status and success, there I invest far more time, energy, and concern. Why? Because I've decided what matters. I've made a judgment about where value lies. The public presentation gets my best effort. The private avodah gets the minimum. The Torah is challenging that entire framework.

This brings us to a question that might seem unrelated but connects directly: Why do we dress the way we do? Recently, my daughter asked a simple but profound question: "Why do we have to wear so many clothes?" On the surface, it was about comfort. But the deeper question is about identity, about representation, about what our external presentation communicates.

The Kohen Gadol doesn't choose his garments based on comfort or personal preference. He wears what he's commanded to wear because his clothing represents something beyond himself. It's not decoration. It's definition.

V. From Wherever We Want to Where Hashem Chooses

The parsha continues with another fundamental shift in how avodah is performed. Previously, going back to the time of the Avos, people would bring korbanos wherever they felt moved to do so. Avraham built a mizbei'ach at one location, Yaakov at another, based on where they experienced connection with Hashem. But now the Torah establishes

something different. There is a makom, a designated place. In the midbar, it was the Mishkan. Later, it would be the Beis HaMikdash in Yerushalayim. Not wherever inspiration strikes. Not wherever feels spiritually significant. Where Hashem designates. "This is where it will be," Hashem says. "This is what is kadosh. And I will tell you what else is kadosh."

VI. Blood, Boundaries, and Moral Clarity

From there, the Torah moves into detailed halachos about blood. The prohibition against consuming blood is exhaustive, filled with specifications and nuances. It might seem like a small detail, something technical. But it's not small at all. This is where the Torah's message becomes concrete and unavoidable. Even when I can't see the blood. Even when it seems insignificant. Even when everyone around me says it doesn't matter. There is a boundary. There is a structure. There is halacha.

The Torah then addresses giluy arayos, forbidden relationships. These halachos establish moral boundaries that may conflict with what society normalizes, with what human logic might justify, with what the surrounding culture accepts. And the underlying message is consistent: morality is not self-defined. We do not determine right and wrong based on what feels natural or what everyone else is doing. Hashem defines the boundaries, and we align ourselves within them.

VII. Kedoshim Tihyu: The Call to Separation

As we enter Parshas Kedoshim, the Torah gives us the overarching command: "קדשים תהיו כי קדוש אני ה' אלקיכם" (Vayikra 19:2), you shall be holy, for I, Hashem your God, am holy. Kadosh means separated, set apart, distinct. And the Torah immediately grounds this in concrete, practical mitzvos. "איש אמו ואביו תיראו" (Vayikra 19:3), every person shall revere his mother and father. "ואת שבתותי תשמרו", and you shall observe My Sabbaths. "לא תקם ולא תטר" (Vayikra 19:18), you shall not take revenge nor bear a grudge. "ואהבת לרעך כמוך", you shall love your fellow as yourself.

Kedushah is not abstract mysticism. It's how you treat your parents. How you keep Shabbos. How you control your anger. How you respond to insult. How you relate to other people.

VIII. The Sefer HaKuzari's Warning

The Sefer HaKuzari addresses a fundamental challenge: human beings are deeply influenced by their surroundings. What we see repeatedly becomes what we believe is normal. What everyone around us does begins to feel correct. And what feels correct begins to feel true. But that's not truth. That's conditioning. That's socialization. That's cultural conformity mistaken for moral clarity.

Our ideas, our alignments, our sense of what's right and wrong, can become shaped by our drives, our desires, what we see taking place around us. We might think: "Everyone is doing this, so maybe it's okay." Or: "The world has changed, so maybe these old customs

don't apply anymore." The Torah says: No. You are not like the rest of the world. "קדשים תהיו" is not a suggestion. It's a command.

IX. Kadosh Means Separate, Not Isolated

The word kadosh literally means separated. We are a distinct unit, an am kadosh. But this doesn't mean we ignore the world or withdraw from it entirely. We're also commanded to be "אור לגוים", a light to the nations. And you cannot be a light to the nations if you're completely hidden from them. Chassidus teaches that the Ohr Ein Sof is completely separate, completely transcendent. But when it expresses itself through a kli, through a vessel, it becomes something that can be perceived and revealed in this world.

Our separation is like that. We maintain our distinctness, our identity, our boundaries, precisely so that we can be a light. When we dress with tznius, we're not hiding. We're defining ourselves. When we maintain kashrus, avoiding even the blood we cannot see, we're not being overly particular. We're living with precision and awareness.

X. Ancient Prohibitions, Timeless Relevance

Consider giluy arayos, the forbidden relationships detailed in the Torah. Today, people might say: "Most of these prohibitions seem obvious. Of course we wouldn't do those things." But once upon a time, these were the norm in surrounding cultures. There's a reason modern societies eventually created laws against certain family relationships. The genetic issues became undeniable. But even before the science, there was something above it: a moral alignment that human nature, left to itself, doesn't always preserve. If we rely solely on ourselves to determine what is morally correct, we will inevitably miss the mark. What feels acceptable shifts with time, with culture, with social pressure. The Torah provides the fixed standard.

XI. The Model: Aharon and Moshe

We have models for this. Aharon HaKohen, after losing his sons, had to put his personal grief aside and continue the avodah. He had to understand the importance of the structure, the framework, the commandedness of what he was doing. Moshe Rabbeinu, when confronting his older brother about serious matters, knew how to do so with kavod, with respect, in the way that was correct.

And we today must learn the same lesson. We don't eat blood, even when we can't see it. We don't follow the practices of the surrounding culture simply because "everyone is doing it." We don't dress however feels most comfortable if it conflicts with tznius. We don't abandon customs that have sustained us for thousands of years just because "the world has changed." Why? Because we have a guiding light. We have Torah. We have halacha. We have rabbanim. We have Chassidus. We have a mesorah that keeps us on track.

XII. Finding Ourselves by Aligning with Hashem

We are called "קדשים תהיו". Not just to be different for the sake of being different. But to be aligned. To recognize that value, purpose, and kedushah are not self-defined. They are defined by Hashem. Just like the two goats, identical in appearance, but their purpose determined not by human judgment but by the goral, by Hashem's designation. Just like the Kohen Gadol, whose garments and actions are prescribed, not chosen based on personal preference. Just like the makom of the Mishkan, established not wherever we feel inspired but where Hashem chooses.

When we align ourselves with Hashem's framework, when we accept that He defines what is kadosh, when we live as an am kadosh even when the world operates differently, we don't lose ourselves. We find our true selves. Because the goal is not just to be separate. The goal is to be aligned. Aligned with truth. Aligned with purpose. Aligned with the One who created us and knows what we're meant to become.

May we merit to live as kedoshim, maintaining our boundaries and our identity, while shining as an ohr lagoyim, bringing light to a world that desperately needs it.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

- *How do I decide what matters in my life — based on my own judgment or based on what Hashem has told me?*
- *Where am I investing my best effort in what others see, while giving minimum attention to my private avodah?*
- *Am I maintaining my identity as part of an am kadosh while still engaging with the world, or am I blending in completely?*
- *Where am I tempted to dismiss halacha as "just details" when they're actually part of the structure that holds everything together?*
- *What beliefs or behaviors have I absorbed from my surroundings that conflict with Torah values?*
- *How can I be a light to the nations while maintaining the boundaries that define who I am?*